

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ancient History 06 - The Harappan Civilization: Solved Practice Workbook

Ancient Indian History | Topic 06 | Prelims GS-I + GS-I culture and architecture support

Generated 13 August 2026 | Approval state: awaiting explicit user approval

Facts and inferences separated | Contested labels qualified | Qdrant not used



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Verified PYQ Audit and Answer-Key Status

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KEY DATA

Year	Stage/question	Demand	Key status used here
2019	Prelims Q7	Identify the non-Harappan site	INFERRED - local official key unavailable
2021	Prelims Q32	Dholavira water harvesting	INFERRED - local official key unavailable
2025	Prelims Q72	Material of the Dancing Girl	Official local Set-A key verified
2026	Prelims Q8	Archaeological inference from spindle whorls, scales and houses	INFERRED - provisional key is not official
2025	Mains GS-I Q1	Salient features of Harappan architecture	Exact local official paper; model answer supplied

STATIC THEORY

- FACT: The 2019 and 2021 question wordings were cross-checked through live PYQ pages and the repository routing ledger. The 2025 and 2026 stems were read from local papers.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Direct PYQs in package: 5.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A provisional 2026 key is final.

CORRECT: It is treated as non-official and the answer is labelled inferred.

HIGH

Solved Prelims PYQ - 2019 Q7: Non-Harappan Site

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STATIC THEORY

- Which one of the following is not a Harappan site?

- (A) Chanhudaro
- (B) Kot Diji
- (C) Sohgauna
- (D) Desalpur

- **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: C - Sohgauna**

- **Elimination and explanation**

- Chanhudaro was a Harappan craft town, Kot Diji has early and mature Harappan levels, and Desalpur is a fortified Harappan site in Kutch. Sohgauna in Uttar Pradesh is associated with a much later copper-plate inscription and is not a Harappan settlement. Confidence: high.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Distinguish the status of the question paper from the status of the answer key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A coaching key is described as an official UPSC key.

CORRECT: Only a locally held official key is called officially verified in this package.

HIGH**Solved Prelims PYQ - 2021 Q32: Ancient Water Harvesting**

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STATIC THEORY

- Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into connected reservoirs?

- (A) Dholavira
- (B) Kalibangan
- (C) Rakhigarhi
- (D) Ropar

- **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A - Dholavira**

- **Elimination and explanation**

- Dholavira lay between the Manhar and Mansar seasonal streams and used dams, channels, cisterns and at least 16 reservoirs. Kalibangan is especially associated with a ploughed field and fire installations; Rakhigarhi with a large settlement, crafts and cemeteries; Ropar with a long cultural sequence. Confidence: high.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Distinguish the status of the question paper from the status of the answer key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A coaching key is described as an official UPSC key.

CORRECT: Only a locally held official key is called officially verified in this package.

HIGH**Solved Prelims PYQ - 2025 Q72: Dancing Girl Material**

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STATIC THEORY

- The famous female figurine known as 'Dancing Girl', found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of

- (A) carnelian
- (B) clay
- (C) bronze
- (D) gold

- **OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCAL SET-A KEY: C - bronze**

- **Elimination and explanation**

- The figurine is a small bronze made by the lost-wax process. Terracotta female figurines are numerous, which makes clay a plausible distractor, but the named "Dancing Girl" is bronze. The local official 2025 Series-A key records C for Q72.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Distinguish the status of the question paper from the status of the answer key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A coaching key is described as an official UPSC key.

CORRECT: Only a locally held official key is called officially verified in this package.

HIGH**Solved Prelims PYQ - 2026 Q8: Archaeological Inference**

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STATIC THEORY

- Consider the statements: (I) spindle-whorls occur widely in houses but spinning wheels are absent; (II) graduated weights and measurement scales have been discovered; (III) houses were built largely with baked bricks around courtyards, with wells, bathing platforms and large rooms. Which inferences follow: 1. spinning was laborious household work; 2. Harappans possessed scientific knowledge; 3. a common property system emerged?

- (A) 1 and 2 only

- (B) 2 and 3 only

- (C) 1 and 3 only

- (D) 1, 2 and 3

- **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A - 1 and 2 only**

- **Elimination and explanation**

- Inference 1 is reasonable because common household spindle whorls without spinning wheels indicate manual domestic production. Inference 2 is supported by standardized graduated scales and weights. Inference 3 is invalid: a house plan cannot establish legal ownership or common property. The locally held 2026 key is provisional, so this solution is explicitly inferred. Confidence: high.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Distinguish the status of the question paper from the status of the answer key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A coaching key is described as an official UPSC key.

CORRECT: Only a locally held official key is called officially verified in this package.

HIGH

Solved Mains PYQ - 2025 GS-I Q1: Harappan Architecture

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Discuss the salient features of the Harappan architecture. (Answer in 150 words)

- **Demand**

- Discuss requires a compact account of defining architectural features, site variation and one source caution.

- **Model answer**

- Harappan architecture combined civic coordination with regional adaptation rather than royal or temple monumentality.

- First, planned streets, side lanes and courtyard houses created ordered residential blocks. At Mohenjo-daro, private wells, bathing floors and covered drains connected households to a citywide sanitation system; this proves sustained engineering and maintenance, although it does not reveal the governing institution.

- Second, standardized mud and baked bricks, commonly in the 1:2:4 ratio, enabled modular construction. Harappa's platforms and Mohenjo-daro's elevated western mound show large-scale labour mobilisation, but "citadel" need not mean a royal fortress.

- Third, public water works were exceptional: the waterproof Great Bath used gypsum mortar and bitumen, while Dholavira channelled the Manhar and Mansar streams into reservoirs and used dressed stone. These sites demonstrate distinct solutions within a shared urban tradition.

- Finally, Lothal's brick basin and the buildings called "granaries" show functional specialization, but their labels remain archaeological interpretations.

- Thus, Harappan architecture was standardized, water-conscious and civic-functional, yet diverse and textually anonymous.

- **Why this earns marks**

- It directly answers "salient features", uses Mohenjo-daro, Harappa, Dholavira and Lothal as analysed evidence, includes regional variation and qualifies contested labels within a 10-mark structure.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 1 - Questions 1-4

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q1. Which sequence best represents the broad Harappan phases?**

- (A) Early c.3300-2600, Mature c.2600-1900, Late c.1900-1300 BCE

- (B) Mature, Early, Late

- (C) Neolithic, Iron Age, Historic

- (D) Early c.1500-1000, Mature c.1000-600, Late c.600-300 BCE

- **Answer: A Explanation:** The calibrated broad sequence is Early, Mature and Late. Dates are approximate and site-specific.

- **Q2. Why is 'Harappan civilization' generally the safest label?**

- (A) It proves Harappa was the political capital

- (B) It follows the archaeological convention of naming a culture after its first identified site without confining it to one river valley

- (C) It proves all sites were identical
- (D) It is the name found in the script
- **Answer: B Explanation:** The label avoids restricting the culture to the Indus or disputed Sarasvati identification.
- **Q3. Which is the easternmost commonly cited Harappan site?**
- (A) Manda
- (B) Malvan
- (C) Alamgirpur
- (D) Sutkagen-dor
- **Answer: C Explanation:** Alamgirpur in western Uttar Pradesh marks the eastern reach in the standard distribution.
- **Q4. Who began excavation at Harappa in 1921?**
- (A) John Marshall
- (B) R. D. Banerji
- (C) Mortimer Wheeler
- (D) Daya Ram Sahni
- **Answer: D Explanation:** Daya Ram Sahni began excavation at Harappa; Banerji worked at Mohenjo-daro.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 2 - Questions 5-8

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q5. Which site best corrects the universal two-part citadel-lower-town model?**
- (A) Dholavira
- (B) Chanhudaro
- (C) Sutkagen-dor
- (D) Ropar
- **Answer: A Explanation:** Dholavira had multiple enclosed sectors, including castle, bailey, middle town and lower town.
- **Q6. The most defensible description of Chanhudaro is**
- (A) a Vedic sacrificial centre
- (B) an unfortified Harappan craft town noted for bead, seal, shell and weight production
- (C) a late Mauryan port
- (D) the northernmost Harappan settlement
- **Answer: B Explanation:** Chanhudaro is a key specialist production centre and lacked a conventional citadel.

- **Q7. Which pairing is incorrect?**

- (A) Harappa - Cemetery R-37
- (B) Kalibangan - ploughed field
- (C) Mohenjo-daro - dockyard basin
- (D) Dholavira - reservoirs

- **Answer: C Explanation:** The dockyard/basin is at Lothal; Mohenjo-daro is associated with the Great Bath.

- **Q8. Which reported find is most appropriate for a caution about the horse?**

- (A) Great Bath
- (B) Dholavira signboard
- (C) Harappa granary
- (D) Debated equid bones at Surkotada

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Surkotada's bones are debated; horse evidence is rare and not culturally defining.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 3 - Questions 9-12

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q9. What does the mature 1:2:4 brick ratio most securely indicate?**

- (A) Shared modular construction norms
- (B) One known emperor
- (C) A deciphered building code
- (D) Absence of regional variation

- **Answer: A Explanation:** The ratio demonstrates standardization and geometric planning, not the exact political mechanism.

- **Q10. Which evidence most strongly supports regular drain maintenance?**

- (A) Unicorn seals
- (B) Covered drains with soak-pits or access points for collecting solid waste
- (C) Female figurines
- (D) Burial pottery

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Soak-pits and drain design imply periodic cleaning to prevent blockage.

- **Q11. Which label must be used with the greatest functional caution at Harappa?**

- (A) Cemetery R-37
- (B) Ravi river

- (C) Granary
- (D) Mature Harappan
- **Answer: C Explanation:** The famous 12-unit structure lacked recovered grain; its granary function is conventional.
- **Q12. Which city is especially associated with numerous private and neighbourhood wells?**
- (A) Kalibangan
- (B) Banawali
- (C) Surkotada
- (D) Mohenjo-daro
- **Answer: D Explanation:** Mohenjo-daro may have had hundreds of wells, perhaps one for every few houses.

HIGH**Hard MCQ Learning Loop 4 - Questions 13-16**

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q13. Which statement about Harappan agriculture is safest?**
- (A) Crop packages varied by region and included cereals, pulses, oilseeds and fruits
- (B) Only wheat was grown
- (C) Canal irrigation was uniform everywhere
- (D) Rice dominated every city
- **Answer: A Explanation:** Regional crop diversity is a central finding; uniform monoculture is false.
- **Q14. What does the Kalibangan field surface most directly show?**
- (A) Royal ownership
- (B) Cross-furrow ploughing before or during the Harappan sequence
- (C) Iron ploughshares
- (D) Canal bureaucracy
- **Answer: B Explanation:** The preserved furrows are direct evidence of plough agriculture, not of iron or ownership.
- **Q15. Which finding provides direct molecular evidence for dairy processing?**
- (A) Bull seal
- (B) Terracotta plough
- (C) Lipid residues in Harappan pottery
- (D) Cattle figurine
- **Answer: C Explanation:** Absorbed lipid analysis identifies dairy fats more directly than images or bone presence.

- **Q16. Which animal statement is most accurate?**

- (A) Horse dominated transport
- (B) Elephant was absent from imagery
- (C) All camel bones are securely mature Harappan
- (D) Cattle and buffalo were more economically important than the rare/debated horse

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Cattle dominate faunal and economic evidence; the horse is marginal and disputed.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 5 - Questions 17-20

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q17. The 'Dancing Girl' demonstrates which technique?**

- (A) Lost-wax bronze casting
- (B) Iron forging
- (C) Stone inlay
- (D) Faience glazing

- **Answer: A Explanation:** The bronze was made by cire perdue or lost-wax casting.

- **Q18. Why does abundant pure copper not prove technological backwardness?**

- (A) Tin was unknown everywhere
- (B) Alloy choice varied by function, availability, preference and recycling
- (C) Bronze cannot hold an edge
- (D) Copper was coinage

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Harappans alloyed tools when useful; material choice was economic and technical.

- **Q19. Which site is strongly associated with shell-working specialization?**

- (A) Rakhigarhi
- (B) Harappa
- (C) Nageshwar
- (D) Manda

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Nageshwar was a specialist shell-working settlement, especially for bangles.

- **Q20. The widespread occurrence of spindle whorls most directly indicates**

- (A) coin minting
- (B) state taxation

- (C) horse breeding
- (D) spinning of fibres in household or workshop contexts
- **Answer: D Explanation:** Spindle whorls are direct equipment for spinning; organization and gender remain inferential.

HIGH**Hard MCQ Learning Loop 6 - Questions 21-24**

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q21. Which best describes the Harappan weight system?**
 - (A) Binary lower series with decimal relationships at higher units
 - (B) Only multiples of ten
 - (C) Only multiples of sixteen
 - (D) No standardization
 - **Answer: A Explanation:** Upinder Singh records binary lower units and decimal higher values.
- **Q22. A shell scale at Mohenjo-daro and ivory scale at Lothal support**
 - (A) a common property system
 - (B) graduated measurement and technical precision
 - (C) alphabetic writing
 - (D) coinage
 - **Answer: B Explanation:** They support metrology, not legal ownership or coins.
- **Q23. Which statement about the script is incorrect?**
 - (A) It is undeciphered
 - (B) Most texts are short
 - (C) It was always boustrophedon
 - (D) It was generally written right-to-left
 - **Answer: C Explanation:** Only some multi-line texts used alternating directions; the usual direction was right-to-left.
- **Q24. The Dholavira signboard most securely demonstrates**
 - (A) the city's deciphered name
 - (B) universal literacy
 - (C) a Sanskrit inscription
 - (D) large-scale civic display of Harappan signs
 - **Answer: D Explanation:** The symbols were publicly displayed, but their content is unread.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 7 - Questions 25-28

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q25. Which was probably the most structurally important exchange network?**

- (A) Internal and subcontinental movement of food, raw materials and crafts
- (B) Only Mesopotamian luxury trade
- (C) Roman trade
- (D) Coin-based trade

- **Answer: A Explanation:** Internal procurement sustained the settlement hierarchy and craft system.

- **Q26. Dilmun is generally identified with**

- (A) Oman
- (B) Bahrain
- (C) Afghanistan
- (D) Sindh

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Dilmun is usually Bahrain; Magan is associated with Oman/Makran.

- **Q27. Which evidence weakens claims of intensive direct Mesopotamian merchant presence in Harappan cities?**

- (A) Harappan beads at Ur
- (B) Meluhha references
- (C) Very few Mesopotamian seals/sealings in Harappan contexts
- (D) Coastal boats

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Contact is secure, but the asymmetry and low quantity limit claims of direct intensive presence.

- **Q28. No coinage is known; Harappan transactions were supported by**

- (A) paper money
- (B) punch-marked coins
- (C) Roman denarii
- (D) weights, commodities, seals and other media of exchange

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Standard weights and seals operated in a pre-coin exchange system.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 8 - Questions 29-32

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q29. Which inference from unequal house size is safest?**

- (A) Differences in household wealth, status or function probably existed
- (B) A known four-varna order existed
- (C) Every large house was a palace
- (D) Property was common

- **Answer: A Explanation:** House variation supports differentiation but not a named legal or caste system.

- **Q30. Which polity conclusion is best supported?**

- (A) A named priest-king empire
- (B) Organized authority existed, but its scale and personnel remain debated
- (C) No state of any kind
- (D) A modern republic

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Infrastructure, standards and networks support authority; exact constitutional form is unknown.

- **Q31. Which does not by itself prove centralized empire?**

- (A) Public works
- (B) Long-distance outpost
- (C) Cultural uniformity
- (D) All of these require interpretation rather than automatic proof

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Uniformity and coordination have several possible institutional explanations.

- **Q32. Which evidence is least characteristic of Harappan elite display?**

- (A) Precious ornaments
- (B) Large houses
- (C) Citadel buildings
- (D) Royal tombs with named kings

- **Answer: D Explanation:** No named royal tomb tradition has been identified.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 9 - Questions 33-36

Prelims GS-I +
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q33. How should female figurines usually be described first?**

- (A) As varied terracotta female representations whose functions differ
- (B) As one universal Mother Goddess
- (C) As queens
- (D) As proof of matriarchy

- **Answer: A Explanation:** Neutral description and context precede a religious label.

- **Q34. The safest term for the central figure on the Pashupati seal is**

- (A) Shiva beyond doubt
- (B) a horned seated figure/deity with a contested proto-Shiva interpretation
- (C) a Vedic rishi
- (D) a historical king

- **Answer: B Explanation:** The later Shiva connection is debated and the Harappan name is unknown.

- **Q35. What is conclusively absent from identified Harappan architecture?**

- (A) Ritual activity
- (B) Household cults
- (C) A securely identified monumental temple
- (D) Bathing structures

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Ritual evidence exists, but no building is conclusively a monumental temple.

- **Q36. Why does goddess imagery not prove matriarchy?**

- (A) Figurines are modern
- (B) Women did not exist
- (C) Burials are absent
- (D) Religious representation and ordinary social power are different variables

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Divine femininity cannot be converted directly into inheritance or political authority.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 10 - Questions 37-40

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q37. Which theory of Harappan decline has the least archaeological support?**

- (A) A violent Aryan invasion destroying the cities
- (B) Regional floods
- (C) River and drought stress
- (D) Network and political reorganisation

- **Answer: A Explanation:** No invasion horizon or single massacre event supports the old theory.

- **Q38. Repeated silt layers are most relevant to decline at**

- (A) Dholavira
- (B) Mohenjo-daro
- (C) Rakhigarhi
- (D) Shortughai

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Mohenjo-daro faced repeated Indus flooding; this is a local mechanism.

- **Q39. The 2025 river-drought study explicitly supports which conclusion?**

- (A) Climate had no role
- (B) One drought ended every city
- (C) Persistent water stress likely contributed, alongside social and economic pressures
- (D) Aryan invasion caused drought

- **Answer: C Explanation:** The study models long droughts but retains a multi-factor societal interpretation.

- **Q40. Which phrase best describes the post-1900 BCE transition?**

- (A) Instant extinction
- (B) Unchanged empire
- (C) Second urbanisation
- (D) Uneven deurbanisation, localisation and continuity

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Urban institutions declined while rural and regional cultures persisted.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 11 - Questions 41-44

Prelims GS-I +
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STATIC THEORY

- Q41. Late Harappan agricultural change included

- (A) greater diversification and, in some regions, double cropping
- (B) complete abandonment of farming
- (C) iron plough monopoly
- (D) only barley everywhere

- **Answer: A Explanation:** Millets, rice, pulses and varied seasonal strategies became more visible.

- Q42. Overlap between Late Harappan and PGW levels proves

- (A) one language
- (B) contact or chronological overlap, not automatic ethnic identity
- (C) a centralized empire
- (D) script decipherment

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Material overlap needs contextual interpretation and cannot establish ethnicity alone.

- Q43. Which continuity claim is weakest?

- (A) Some pottery forms persisted
- (B) Population continuity is possible
- (C) The entire mature urban system survived unchanged
- (D) Crops and crafts continued selectively

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Cities, script and standards declined; continuity was selective.

- Q44. Which best characterizes Harappan-Vedic relationship?

- (A) Complete identity
- (B) No interaction ever
- (C) Mature Harappans were Steppe pastoralists
- (D) Different evidentiary and chronological formations with later interaction and admixture

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Avoid both timeless identity and total discontinuity.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 12 - Questions 45-48

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q45. Radiocarbon dating most directly dates**

- (A) the sampled organic event within a probability range
- (B) the name of a ruler
- (C) a pottery style forever
- (D) a language

- **Answer: A Explanation:** The date belongs to the sample and context, not automatically the whole culture.

- **Q46. Stable isotope analysis of human remains can help reconstruct**

- (A) script signs
- (B) diet, mobility and water-source histories
- (C) political titles
- (D) seal ownership

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Isotopic signals address biological and environmental history.

- **Q47. What is the main limit of the 2019 Rakhigarhi genome?**

- (A) It was not ancient
- (B) It was from Mesopotamia
- (C) One individual cannot represent every region, period or social group
- (D) It identified the script

- **Answer: C Explanation:** The study was path-breaking but sample breadth is crucial.

- **Q48. As of 13 August 2026, the new Rakhigarhi skeletal programme has**

- (A) published a final migration map
- (B) deciphered the script
- (C) proved a religion
- (D) transferred samples and planned analyses; results remain pending

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Reports describe work initiated, not completed conclusions.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 1 - Questions 49-52

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q49. A candidate writes that the 'citadel housed kings'. What is the best correction?**

- (A) It was a raised/enclosed sector; occupants and functions are not securely known
- (B) No citadels existed
- (C) Every citadel was a temple
- (D) Citadel means cemetery

- **Answer: A Explanation:** Use observed form first and qualify the social interpretation.

- **Q50. Which replacement best fixes 'Harappans worshipped Shiva'?**

- (A) They had no ritual
- (B) A horned seated figure has a contested proto-Shiva interpretation
- (C) The seal is Vedic
- (D) Shiva is written on the seal

- **Answer: B Explanation:** The object is secure; the named continuity is debated.

- **Q51. Which sentence correctly uses the Lothal evidence?**

- (A) Lothal had no water structure
- (B) The basin was certainly a rice field
- (C) The brick basin is conventionally identified as a dockyard, though function remains interpretive
- (D) The script calls it a dock

- **Answer: C Explanation:** This preserves the leading interpretation without false certainty.

- **Q52. Which statement avoids the horse trap?**

- (A) Horse dominated Harappan warfare
- (B) Horse was unknown in Asia
- (C) Every equid bone is a horse
- (D) Reported horse remains are rare/debated and the civilization was not horse-centred

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Frequency and context matter more than an isolated disputed identification.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 2 - Questions 53-56

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q53. What should follow a claim that Dholavira shows water governance?**

- (A) Named evidence: dams, channels and reservoirs; proof of collective coordination; exact institution unknown
- (B) A claim of modern democracy
- (C) A Vedic quotation
- (D) No evidence

- **Answer: A Explanation:** This is the claim-evidence-analysis-qualification chain.

- **Q54. Which is the best treatment of the 2025 drought study?**

- (A) Ignore it because it is recent
- (B) Use it as evidence of prolonged water stress while retaining multi-causal explanation
- (C) Call it proof of one drought
- (D) Use it to prove invasion

- **Answer: B Explanation:** The paper itself stresses climatic, social and economic interplay.

- **Q55. Which interpretation of weights is too strong?**

- (A) They aided exchange
- (B) They show metrology
- (C) They prove one empire beyond doubt
- (D) They show standardization

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Several political and corporate mechanisms can produce standards.

- **Q56. Which conclusion about 2026 Rakhigarhi analysis is valid now?**

- (A) It proved Steppe ancestry
- (B) It proved no migration
- (C) It published final isotope results
- (D) Samples were transferred and methods planned; findings await publication

- **Answer: D Explanation:** Status discipline prevents fabrication.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 3 - Questions 57-60

Prelims GS-I +
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q57. Which evidence pair best supports craft specialization?**

- (A) Unfinished beads plus drills and workshop waste at Chanhudaro
- (B) One finished bead alone
- (C) One seal without context
- (D) A large house only

- **Answer: A Explanation:** Production debris and tools identify manufacture better than a finished object.

- **Q58. Which answer best handles continuity?**

- (A) Everything ended
- (B) Some people, crops and crafts continued while integrated urban institutions declined
- (C) The empire remained unchanged
- (D) Only script survived

- **Answer: B Explanation:** Continuity and rupture operated in different domains.

- **Q59. Which is an archaeobotanical inference?**

- (A) A seal identifies a king
- (B) A wall proves taxation
- (C) Carbonized crop remains help reconstruct plant use and agriculture
- (D) A skeleton deciphers language

- **Answer: C Explanation:** Archaeobotany studies plant remains; sampling and context still matter.

- **Q60. What is the final discipline for a Harappan answer?**

- (A) Avoid examples
- (B) State only debates
- (C) Claim certainty everywhere
- (D) Separate fact, inference and unresolved interpretation

- **Answer: D Explanation:** This preserves both content and source criticism.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 1 - Civic Urbanism

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Harappan urbanism was civic-functional rather than monumentally royal. Examine in 150 words.

- **Demand**

- Examine requires a clear thesis, supporting civic evidence and a qualification about authority.

- **Model answer**

- Harappan cities displayed authority most visibly through shared civic systems rather than royal tombs, palaces or monumental temples.

- At Mohenjo-daro, household bathing floors, hundreds of wells and covered drains joined private routines to citywide waste disposal. This proves coordinated construction and maintenance, although the responsible institution is unnamed. The Great Bath adds waterproof brickwork, gypsum mortar and bitumen, showing collective engineering; ritual use remains probable rather than certain.

- Dholavira converted seasonal flow from the Manhar and Mansar into reservoirs and used stone architecture across multiple enclosed sectors. The evidence demonstrates regional adaptation within shared urban norms. Harappa's platforms, walls and craft suburb likewise show labour mobilisation, while standard 1:2:4 bricks made construction modular across distant settlements.

- Yet civic emphasis does not imply an egalitarian or non-state society. Fortifications, house inequality and controlled craft networks suggest organized authority and social ranking.

- Thus, Harappan power was materially expressed through durable urban services and standards, but whether rulers were kings, councils or corporate elites remains unresolved.

- **Why this earns marks**

- The answer uses Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira and Harappa as analysed evidence, answers the royal-versus-civic contrast and avoids turning uncertainty into denial of authority.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 2 - Dholavira Water Management

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Explain how Dholavira represents regional adaptation within Harappan urbanism. Answer in 150 words.

- **Demand**

- Explain requires a causal account linking environment, design and wider Harappan standards.

- **Model answer**

- Dholavira shows that Harappan integration did not erase ecological adaptation.

- The city stood on Khadir island in an arid Rann landscape between the seasonal Manhar and Mansar streams. Dams and channels diverted runoff into at least 16 reservoirs and cisterns, proving that urban survival depended on planned water capture rather than a perennial river alone. The design converted scarce seasonal flow into stored civic supply; exact management institutions remain unknown.

- Architecturally, Dholavira used dressed sandstone with mud-brick, unlike the baked-brick emphasis at Mohenjo-daro. Its castle, bailey, middle town, lower town and open "stadium" also challenge the universal two-part citadel/lower-town model. The large signboard indicates public display of the shared script, while standardized bricks and seals connect the city to wider Harappan norms.

- Therefore, Dholavira was simultaneously regional and Harappan: local stone, water engineering and a distinctive plan operated within a common technological and symbolic world.

- **Why this earns marks**

- It links aridity to named hydraulic evidence, adds plan and material variation, and qualifies administrative and functional labels.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 3 - Interpreting Harappan Religion

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Why must Harappan religious evidence be interpreted cautiously? Discuss in 150 words.

- **Demand**

- Discuss requires examples of evidence, competing readings and a reasoned conclusion.

- **Model answer**

- Harappan religion is reconstructed without a deciphered text or a securely identified temple, so objects cannot be converted directly into doctrines.

- Female terracottas vary greatly and are unevenly distributed: some fan-headdress figures may have served household ritual, while others could be toys or short-lived votives. This proves representational diversity, not one universal Mother Goddess or matriarchy.

- The Mohenjo-daro horned seated figure has been called proto-Shiva or Pashupati, but its sex, number of faces, yogic posture and connection with later Shiva remain debated. It is safest to call it a horned deity/figure. Similarly, Kalibangan fire installations may indicate community ritual, yet their shape does not make them Vedic altars.

- Pipal, animal and composite motifs on seals likely carried symbolic or cultic meaning, but unread inscriptions prevent narrative certainty.

- Hence, a sound interpretation proceeds from form and context to alternatives, accepting ritual activity while rejecting confident names and a single standardized creed.

- **Why this earns marks**

- It analyses three precise evidence groups, states what each proves and adds a source limitation rather than merely listing artefacts.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 1 - Integration and Regional Variation

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** The Harappan civilization combined striking integration with strong regional variation. Analyse in 250 words.

- Demand

- Analyse requires dimensions showing both unity and difference, followed by an explanation of how they coexisted.

- Model answer

- The Mature Harappan phase was an integration era, but its unity was a networked cultural achievement rather than uniform replication.

- Integration is clearest in technology and transactions. The 1:2:4 brick ratio, accurate cubical weights, shared seals and a common script linked settlements across a vast zone. Chert blades, carnelian beads and shell products moved through internal routes, while planned streets, drains and bathing floors reflected common technical expectations. These features prove coordination and sustained interaction, although they do not alone establish one empire.

- Regional variation appears in urban form. Mohenjo-daro relied heavily on wells and a Great Bath; Dholavira used stone, multiple walled sectors and stream-fed reservoirs; Kalibangan lacked Mohenjo-daro-style lower-town street drains; Lothal's basin reflected a coastal hydraulic setting; Chanhudaro specialized in crafts without a monumental citadel.

- Subsistence also varied. Wheat-barley packages were prominent in the north-west; rice and millets had stronger roles in parts of Gujarat and other zones. Coastal settlements exploited fish and shell, while inland centres drew on cattle and floodplain agriculture. Ritual evidence differed too: Kalibangan fire installations and site-specific female figurine frequencies resist a single creed.

- The best explanation is "coordinated diversity": exchange, mobile specialists, shared symbols and organized authority circulated standards, while ecology, raw materials and local traditions shaped implementation.

- Thus, Harappan civilization was integrated enough to be recognisable and diverse enough to demand regional history.

- Why this earns marks

- The answer uses more than six named sites, separates material, urban, subsistence and ritual dimensions, explains the relationship and qualifies the empire inference.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 2 - Craft and Exchange Economy

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Assess the role of craft specialisation and exchange networks in sustaining Harappan urbanism. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Assess requires contribution, mechanisms, evidence and limits, not a catalogue of crafts.

- Model answer

- Craft specialisation and exchange converted ecological diversity into an urban system, but long-distance Mesopotamian commerce was only one limited layer.

- Cities concentrated skilled production. Chanhudaro yielded bead factories, drills and unfinished steatite objects; Lothal had bead and copper workshops; Rakhigarhi had a lapidary area with thousands of unfinished stones; Nageshwar specialized in shell bangles. These contexts prove organized multi-stage production, not merely possession of finished goods.

- Technical standardisation widened markets. Accurate stone weights, graduated scales, seals and modular bricks reduced transaction and quality-control problems across distant settlements. Yet standards could have been maintained by states, merchants, corporate specialists or inherited training; the mechanism remains debated.

- Internal procurement was fundamental. Rohri chert, Gujarat carnelian, coastal shell, Rajasthan/highland metals and Badakhshan lapis reached workshops through carts, pack animals, rivers and sea routes. Randall Law's mineral-provenance research shows that many essential resources came from within or near the wider Harappan zone, proving the structural importance of subcontinental networks.

- Mesopotamian texts name Meluhha, and Harappan beads and seals reached Ur and Gulf sites through Dilmun and Magan. However, the low quantity of reciprocal artefacts and absence of strong Mesopotamian merchant evidence in Harappan cities warn against making this trade the cause of urbanism.

- Therefore, craft-exchange networks sustained specialization, hierarchy and interdependence; their internal density mattered more than external glamour.

- Why this earns marks

- It analyses workshops, standards, resource routes, provenance science and the Mesopotamian debate with six precise evidence units and a graded assessment.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 3 - Scientific Archaeology

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** How have scientific methods changed the reconstruction of Harappan life? Discuss with examples in 250 words.

- Demand

- Discuss requires method, named finding, historical value and limitation across several evidence families.

- Model answer

- Scientific archaeology has shifted Harappan history from monument description toward testable reconstructions of chronology, diet, mobility, health, resources and climate.

- Calibrated radiocarbon dating anchors the urban phase broadly at c. 2600-1900 BCE and reveals site-specific sequences; it dates samples probabilistically, not an entire culture automatically. Archaeobotany at Balu, Kanmer and other sites identifies cereals, pulses, oilseeds and fruits, demonstrating regional crop diversity while remaining sensitive to recovery bias.

- Zooarchaeological age profiles at sites such as Shikarpur distinguish older cattle kept for traction/secondary products from younger sheep-goats killed for meat. Lipid residues in Kotada Bhadli pottery provide direct evidence of dairy processing; they identify vessel use, not the complete diet.

- Human osteology and dental pathology at Harappa Cemetery R-37 reconstruct arthritis, agricultural dental stress and relatively good health in that sample, while warning against treating one cemetery as the whole population. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome indicated ancestry related to ancient Iranian and South Asian hunter-gatherer lineages with little/no immediate Steppe contribution in one individual; genetics cannot reveal language or religion.

- Mineralogical and isotope provenance studies trace chert, lapis and metals, refining trade routes. Finally, the 2025 palaeohydrological study models persistent river droughts, strengthening a water-stress explanation but explicitly retaining social and economic factors.

- Thus, scientific methods improve resolution when triangulated with context; no laboratory technique removes interpretation.

- Why this earns marks

- It covers dating, plants, animals, residues, human biology, aDNA, provenance and climate, with a named example and limitation for each major claim.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 1 - Decline and Transformation

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Critically examine the causes and character of Harappan decline. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Critically examine requires testing competing causes, regional evidence, rejected theories and a verdict on decline versus transformation.

- Model answer

- Harappan decline was not one civilizational crash but an uneven transition from mature urban integration to regional Late Harappan worlds.

- The invasion hypothesis is weakest. Wheeler linked Rig Vedic fort imagery and scattered Mohenjo-daro skeletons to Aryan conquest, but the bodies belong to different contexts, no battle horizon appears, and Cemetery H is separated from mature levels. It therefore cannot explain the urban transition.

- Environmental mechanisms were real but regional. Repeated silt layers show flooding at Mohenjo-daro; Ghaggar-Hakra settlement contraction is consistent with reduced flow after river reorganisation; Dholavira's dependence on reservoirs made water availability crucial. The December 2025 river-drought study modelled persistent droughts between about 4400 and 3400 years BP and linked reduced rainfall/streamflow to population dispersal, but explicitly retained social and economic pressures.

- Economic and political networks also changed. Reduced standard weights, seals, writing and specialized urban crafts indicate weakening integration. Mesopotamian contact declined, but because external trade was limited relative to internal exchange, it cannot be the sole cause. Environmental overuse, salinity and local resource pressure are plausible but hard to quantify.

- Character varied: Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira declined gradually, whereas Kalibangan and Banawali ended more abruptly. After c. 1900 BCE, cities became fewer, settlements shifted east and south, and agriculture diversified into millets, rice and double cropping. Jhukar, Cemetery H, Rangpur and eastern sites retained selected pottery, crafts and signs.

- Therefore, "deurbanisation" or "metamorphosis" is superior to "collapse": institutional integration broke down, but populations adapted and cultural continuities persisted.

- Why this earns marks

- The answer evaluates seven evidence units, rejects an outdated theory, integrates a dated current study, explains regional variation and ends with a precise decline-versus-transformation verdict.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 2 - State and Society

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** What can archaeological evidence reveal about Harappan polity and social organisation, and where are its limits? Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- The two-part demand requires positive reconstruction and explicit evidentiary limits.

- Model answer

- Archaeology securely reveals coordinated authority and social differentiation, but it cannot name the Harappan constitution.

- State-like coordination appears in standardized weights, script and 1:2:4 bricks; the construction and maintenance of Dholavira reservoirs, Mohenjo-daro drains and Harappa platforms; specialist centres such as Chanhudaro; and the distant outpost at Shortughai. These prove labour mobilisation, communication and regulated networks. Fortifications suggest control and possible coercion, although weapons and warfare imagery are comparatively limited.

- Several models remain viable. Piggott's centralized priest-king empire explains uniformity but lacks palaces, royal tombs, ruler images and king lists. Fairervis stressed community administration and ritual interdependence; Kenoyer proposes competing urban elites, including merchants, ritual specialists and resource controllers; Possehl's corporate model allows councils rather than monarchs. Multiple city-states or regionally varied states are also plausible because Rakhigarhi, Dholavira, Harappa and Mohenjo-daro were all major centres.

- Social differentiation is visible in unequal houses, precious ornament hoards, differentiated burials, craft locations and occupational diversity. Allamdino's rich village hoard shows wealth was not exclusively urban. Yet house form cannot prove property law, and modest graves cannot define a class system. Claims of caste are especially speculative.

- Gender and belief are even harder to reconstruct. Female figurines do not prove matriarchy; a horned seal figure does not securely identify Shiva; the "priest-king" is a modern nickname.

- Thus, the evidence supports organized authority, ranked society and occupational specialization, while the undeciphered script prevents certainty about rulers, laws, classes and ideology.

- Why this earns marks

- It meets both halves, compares four scholarly models, links each claim to named evidence and repeatedly defines the boundary between secure inference and overreach.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 3 - Cultural Relationships and Identity

Prelims GS-I +
GS-I culture and
architecture
support Ancient
Indian History

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Discuss Harappan relationships with preceding, contemporary and successor cultures without making simplistic identity claims. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Discuss across time: origins, contemporaries, Late Harappan successors and Vedic relationship, with source criticism.

- Model answer

- Harappan history is best understood as interaction among changing archaeological traditions, not as the biography of one timeless ethnic community.

- Preceding roots are local and regional. Seventh-millennium farming in Baluchistan established cultivation, herding and mud-brick settlement. Early Harappan Kot Diji, Rehman Dheri, Kalibangan I, Harappa and Dholavira added fortification, planning, wheeled transport, craft specialization, early signs and exchange. M. R. Mughal's assemblage-based work therefore interprets this as a formative phase rather than an imported Mesopotamian civilization.

- During the Mature phase, Harappan cities interacted with contemporary Neolithic-Chalcolithic and pastoral groups. Rajasthan copper zones, Gujarat stone and shell specialists, highland mineral suppliers and village farmers participated in exchange. Possession of a Harappan bead or pottery style, however, does not make every rural community ethnically Harappan.

- After c. 1900 BCE, Jhukar, Cemetery H, Rangpur/Rojdi and eastern Late Harappan settlements preserved selected ceramics, crafts, signs and crops while cities, standardized weights and writing declined. Overlap with OCP and PGW at some sites indicates contact and sequence, not a single people.

- The Mature Harappan and conventional Rig Vedic horizons differ in chronology and material package: cities, script and baked-brick systems contrast with the pastoral-textual Rig Vedic world. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome also lacked immediate Steppe ancestry in one individual, but genes cannot identify language. Later migration and admixture are compatible with cultural continuity and interaction.

- Hence, the defensible model is convergence, exchange, migration and selective continuity - neither invasion-driven erasure nor unbroken ethnic identity.

- Why this earns marks

- It uses Early Harappan sites, exchange zones, Late cultures, OCP/PGW, Vedic comparison and aDNA; every identity claim is explicitly bounded by what the evidence can prove.

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI